Instead, now that there was no danger of encountering the Cossacks or the Imperial Persian army in Afghanistan, an announcement was made that several regiments would be withdrawn from the Army of the Indus and a significantly smaller force would be sent into action. Auckland nonetheless made a strong public declaration that he intended to 'prosecute with vigour' the existing plan. 'Of the justice of the course about to be pursued, there cannot exist a reasonable doubt,' he asserted. 'We owe it to our own safety to assist the lawful sovereign of Afghanistan in the recovery of his throne.' The Tripartite Treaty would be honoured, and Shah Shuja would still be 'replaced on the throne of his ancestors'.

On 27 November, the Sikh and Company armies finally converged on the plains of Ferozepur. Lord Auckland's normally cynical ADC, William Osborne, was astonished at the sheer scale of the gathering. 'In the *Champs de Drap d'Or* of Ferozepore, Lord Auckland appeared with the imposing magnificence of an Indian potentate,' he recorded, 'and though the uniforms of the vice-regal staff were eclipsed by the jewels and chain armour of the Sikh sardars, the Governor General with his immense retinue and escort of 15,000 men was quite a match for the monarch of the Punjab.'[12] Emily, unusually, was also completely won over by the spectacle. 'Behind us there was a large amphitheatre of elephants belonging to our own camp,' she wrote. Facing them were 'thousands of Runjeet's followers, all dressed in yellow or red satin, with quantities of their led horses trapped in gold and silver tissues, and all of them sparkling with jewels. I really never saw so dazzling a sight. Three or four Sikhs would look like Astley's [Circus] broke loose, but this immense body of them saves their splendour from being melodramatic.'[13]

Others, however, were less impressed. Sir John Kaye, the future historian of the Afghan War, was a young officer in the artillery at the time, and remembered the first meeting of Lord Auckland and Ranjit Singh as being 'amidst a scene of indescribable uproar and confusion'. Indeed such was the chaos amid the collision of two lines of trumpeting elephants and the subsequent rush to follow the two leaders into the Durbar Tent that many of the Sikh troopers suspected there might be a British plot to do away with their beloved leader 'and began to blow their matches [that is, prime their matchlocks] and grasp their weapons with an air of mingled distrust and ferocity'.[14] Lord Auckland, excited by the hubbub, then 'made a most splashy answer' to Ranjit's speech of welcome 'about their united armies